

General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), a legal regulation that has been directly applicable in its entirety in the European Union since May 25, 2018, marked a turning point in the field of personal data protection and significantly changed the awareness of the importance of personal data protection among businesses and individuals. However, the educational and supervisory activities of the Agency show that compliance with the legislative framework for data protection in the Republic of Croatia is still not satisfactory; therefore, within its advisory role, the Agency is making significant efforts to organize activities aimed at raising awareness about data protection for all target groups. Following consultations held at the Croatian Employers' Association and the Croatian Chamber of Commerce for data controllers/processors and data protection officers, on Thursday, May 25, on the 5th anniversary of the full application of the General Data Protection Regulation, educational activities aimed at citizens and students were also held.

Webinar for Citizens "How to Protect Your Personal Data and What Are My Rights?"

Although awareness of the importance of personal data protection has significantly increased in recent years, citizens unfortunately still very often handle their personal data carelessly and do not know or misinterpret their rights guaranteed by the General Data Protection Regulation. Therefore, the Agency organized a webinar for all interested citizens titled "How to Protect Your Personal Data and What Are My Rights?" to inform citizens about their rights related to the processing of their personal data. For example, citizens are often not aware that they have the right to access their personal data, meaning they have the right to obtain a copy of their personal data that an organization collects about them, as well as the right to be informed about the processing of their personal data. Specifically, when a certain organization collects an individual's data, it must also inform them how their personal data will be used. Thus, when they provide their personal data to any organization, citizens should know that they have the right to ask why and for what purpose their personal data is being processed, to whom it will be forwarded, how long it will be retained, what the legal basis for its processing is, etc. Organizations must be able to provide citizens with answers to such questions, and responses like "because that's the business rule" or "we need it just in case," "I don't know, I was told to do it this way," are not acceptable. Organizations should, in any case, know on what legal basis and for what purposes they collect personal data and educate their employees about this. However, it is important to emphasize that citizens should first turn to the data controller (e.g., the bank where they have a loan, the school, the hospital, etc.) to exercise their rights, and if the data controller does not comply with the request, they can contact the Agency for Personal Data Protection with a request to determine a violation of their rights.

Citizens' Rights

How to Exercise Your Rights

In addition to the rights, which you can also read about here, the Agency's officials touched upon the protection of personal data on the internet during the webinar, as well as the most common online frauds that occur daily, which you can read about in the brochure "How to Protect Your Personal Data Online?"

Education for Third-Grade Students of Rapska Elementary School

Agency officials also spoke about personal data protection on the internet to third-grade students of Rapska Elementary School in Zagreb. Namely, the General Data Protection Regulation recognizes children as a vulnerable group, meaning that children deserve special protection regarding their personal data because they may be less aware of the risks and consequences; therefore, awareness of the importance of personal data protection needs to be built during childhood. Through the education "Let's Learn to Protect Our Own and Others' Personal Data on the Internet," students learned what personal data is, how to properly handle their own and others' personal data, and how it can be misused. However, to also raise awareness of the dangers lurking on the internet, of which students are often unaware, the emphasis of the education was precisely on prevention and protection from all potential dangers. Fake representations, hate speech, identity theft, fraud, pedophilia are just some of the dark sides, and the most widespread problem when using the internet among children and young people is electronic violence, or cyberbullying.